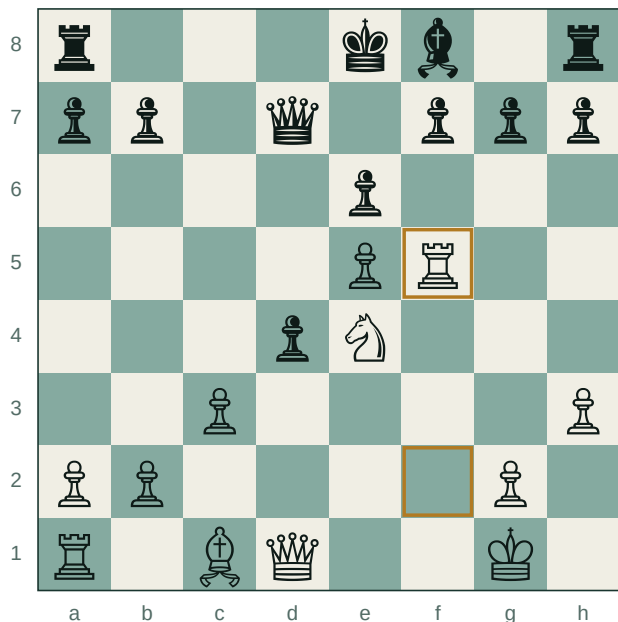


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 15

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 15.Rxf5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

15...exf5 16. Nd6+ Bxd6

15...exf5 The pawn captures the rook on f5. Recorded reply: **16.Nd6+**.

16...Bxd6 The bishop captures the knight on d6.

At the end, nominal material is White 23 / Black 29 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +8. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +8:** the balance goes from -2 to +6. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on f5 and knight on e4. Check for tactical protection.